The Impossible Knife of Memory

By Laurie Halse Anderson

INTRODUCTION

Two million American fought in Iraq and Afghanistan. Most who came back describe themselves as physically and mentally healthy. They move on; the war recedes. But studies suggest that between 20-30% of returning veterans suffer from PTSD, a mental-health condition triggered by some type of terror; or a traumatic brain injury, when the brain is jolted so violently it collides with the inside of the skull, causing psychological damage.

Every war has its after-war: depression, anxiety, nightmares, suicidal thoughts. The wars in Iraq and Afghanistan created roughly 500,000 mentally wounded American veterans. Haley's father is one of them.*

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HALEY: **(Pg 8)** At the end of the last street, past a forgotten cornfield and the ruin of a barn, sat the house that I was supposed to call "home." My father wanted me to remember. . . **(Pg 9)** we were back and living in Gramma's old house.

DAD: **(Pg 8)** Are you sure you don't remember it, Hayley Rose?

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HALEY: I shook my head but kept my mouth shut. It made him sad when I talked about how hard I tried not to remember.

(Pg 9) A few days after we moved in, Daddy got unstuck from time again. The past took over. All he heard were exploding IEDs and incoming mortar rounds; all he saw were body fragments, like an unattached leg still wearing its boot, and shards of shiny bones, sharp as spears. All he tasted was blood.

These attacks had been getting worse for months. They were the only reason I went along with his ridiculous plan to quit trucking and settle down into a so-called "normal life." I let him think that he was right, that spending my senior year in a high school instead of riding shotgun in his big rig was a practical and exciting idea. Truth? I was terrified.

(Pg 6) I swallowed the fear. It's always there - fear - and if you don't stay on top of it, you'll drown.

DAD: **(Pg 301)** *(to audience/self)* The good soldier swears to kill. Fire the cannon, mount the barricade, lock and load. Smell your brother's blood on your shirt. Wipe your

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sister's brains off your face. Die, if you have to, so they'll live. Kill to keep your people alive, live to kill some more. Odysseus had twenty years to shed his battle skin. My grandfather left the battlefield in France and rode home in a ship that crawled across the ocean slowly so he could catch his breath. I get on a plane in hell and get off, hours later, at home. I try to ignore Death, but she's got her arm around my waist, waiting to poison everything I touch.

HALEY: **(Pg 248)** [Here's the] short clean version [of my dad]: two tours in Iraq, two tours in Afghanistan. Earned the Purple Heart. The IED that blew up his truck and his brain and his career. Months in the hospital, then the big welcome home, dog tags turned in, army days over.

(Pg 249-250) He homeschooled me. Unschooled me. It was kind of awesome for a while: him driving, me reading out loud, the two of us talking about everything, fractions and evolution, Abraham Lincoln's cabinet and which Hemingway book is the best.

He got arrested in Arkansas last year. Public drunkenness. He was only in the jail overnight, but he came out completely set on moving back here. Said I needed to go

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to a regular school to get ready for college. I thought the move would be good for him, that he'd hook up with old friends and get a decent job. Instead it's like a bomb had started ticking in his head.

[Dad's] worst yesterdays played on a constant loop in his head and he couldn't (or he wouldn't) stop paying attention to them. At least on the road, there had been times when we'd outrun memories. Now they had us surrounded and were closing in.

(Pg 11) *(calling out)* Dad? [I'm home]! I walked toward his door and gently knocked. I waited. This was where he should ask me how my day went or if I had homework or what I wanted for dinner. Or he could tell me what he felt like eating, because I could cook. Or he could just open the door and talk. *(through the door) Dad*? Did you stay home again?

DAD: It's been a bad day, I'll try harder tomorrow, princess.

HALEY: **(Pg 58)** The dining room table was covered with newspapers, cleaning rods, a double-ended breech-brush, used patches, and rags stained with barrel oil, solvents, and gunpowder. What makes him want to clean all of [his

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guns]. Does he think he's going to need them? **(Pg 60)** How many of the girls in my gym class had to clean up gunpowder and barrel oil after school?

(Pg 87) Dad hated talking about the war and never did it sober. Half the time he didn't even want people to know he was a vet. Strangers often said things like, "Thank you for your service," because they meant it and they thought that was the right thing to do, but the problem was it set off a series of detonations inside my father that sometimes ended with him punching a wall or the face of a jerk in a bar. The worst was when he accidentally found himself in conversation with the family member of a soldier who had been killed. The sadness in their eyes would blow another hole in his brain and then he'd go dead quiet for days.

[Transition: Randy, one of Dad's army friends, called me to ask how things were going.]

RANDY: **(Pg 105-107)** Is Andy seeing a counselor or a shrink?

HALEY: He won't go. [Did you know he's] afraid of bridge overpasses? [He's afraid of] snipers. [And] he'll take huge detours around dumpsters or trash cans 'cause they could

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be hiding an IED. He knows that's stupid, but knowing doesn't stop the panic attacks. Why is he getting worse? He's been back for years.

RANDY: The blood is still flowing. His soul is still bleeding. That's a lot harder to fix than a busted-up leg or traumatic brain injury.

HALEY: *(to audience)* **(Pg 308-309)** [There were days] Dad wouldn't cooperate. We argued about everything: my attitude, the weather, the smell of the garbage. There were the days when he'd disappear in his head without saying a word. He couldn't sleep more than an hour or two at a time without waking up or shouting or screaming. He always apologized for that, once he calmed down.

[A month went by. I came home after classes to find] **(Pg 328)** the door was locked. Dad hadn't locked it in weeks. *(to herself)* ***Get a grip and stop catastrophizing.*** **(Pg 329)** That's when I smelled something burning. Saw smoke rising from the fire pit. I walked over to it, thinking maybe he'd started a fire to cook hotdogs or something. He'd been burning his uniform. The half-melted boots smoldered in the middle.

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I ran to the living room window, cupped my hands to cut down on the glare. The living room had been trashed [and] my father was curled into a ball on the floor. Blood on his face. Blood staining the carpet under his head.

NONONODADDYDADDYNO!!!! **(Pg 330)** [Then] The body moved. Uncurled. It sat up, wiped its face on the front of its T-shirt.

DAD: *(crying)* He'd dead . . . Roy.

HALEY: **(Pg 331)** The war. Another dead friend. Is there anything worse than watching your father cry? When I was a kid, I watched him scaling walls, running miles in the heat wearing full gear. My dad was a superhero who made the world safe. He went overseas with his troops and chased the bad guys out of the mountains so that little kids over there could go to school. **(Pg 332)** I patted his back, waiting for the storm to pass.

(Pg 335) When the sun went down, he opened a bottle [of whiskey], sat me on the couch, and made me listen to stuff I'd heard a million times before: ambushed foot patrols, IEDs ripping open vehicles and bodies, suicide bombers living in ghost villages. The private who was shot

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in the neck. The guy who removed his helmet to wipe the sweat off his head, and the sniper who blew that head into a red mist that hung in the air for a moment before it dropped to the dirt and soaked the ground.

(Pg 336) Around quarter after four, he puked all over the carpet and finally passed out. I laid him on his side, put a bucket by his head, and threw a towel over the mess so the dog wouldn't eat it. I took a long shower to wash off the tears and the stench of whiskey puke. **(Pg 339)** I [called] the cops.

(Pg 343) In the end, they called an ambulance because Dad was so dehydrated. **(Pg 344)** He was alive. I'd been afraid of a day like this forever, but he was alive. At a hospital, getting help. This was a good thing, right? It was all that mattered . . . except . . . What now?

(Pg 360) In [the coming] weeks, Daddy was down to one bottle of Jack every three days. He didn't explode or cry. He spent his nights writing letters at the dining room table. **(Pg 361)** A Christmas tree turned up in our living room the morning of Christmas Eve. [There was] **(Pg 371)** a big, red box [with] dozens of crisp, sealed, sharp-edged

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envelopes. Every envelope had my name on it. In the top-right corner was a date. Half of the envelopes were dated my birthday. The other half were dated December 25, and the years that followed those dates stretched for decades into the future. **(Pg 368)** I shivered . . . [and] my shivering turned into shaking. I pulled out a faded blue bandanna that held two gold rings, one man-sized, the other a little smaller, and one Purple Heart.

(Pg 370) He wasn't in the kitchen or the living room or the dining room . . . so where? *(pause)* **(Pg 377)** I know where he is . . . I know how he's going to do it. *(pause)* [But] I didn't know I was right until I turned off Route 15 onto Quarry Road and saw boot prints that cut through the snow all the way up the hill. **(Pg 378)** From the top I saw him, my father, a dark lump sitting in a hollow of snow a foot away from where the earth ended.

(Pg 379) *(softly)* Daddy, please. **(Pg 381)** I know you have nightmares and you saw horrible things, but . . . *(choking up)* but I don't care. I want my dad back. I want you to be brave again, the way you used to be! *(she moves closer to the edge with her dad)*

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DAD: **(Pg 382)** Go back, Hayley Rose, you're too close to the edge.

HALEY: *(to her dad)* You [don't] understand. I've been standing on the edge with you for years. **(Pg 383)** That feeling you have, Daddy, that you want me to be safe, you want me to stay alive? I feel that way about you all the time. If you kill yourself, then every minute of your life has been wasted. When I got stuck or confused, you used to say, "We'll figure it out." I love you, Daddy. I know we'll figure it out! **(Pg 391)** You can't do this, you can't quit!

(to audience) **(Pg 385)** If this were a fairy tale, I'd stick in the "Happily Ever After" right here. But this was my life, so it was a little more complicated than that.

(Pg 386) The fairly solid rim of snow [that] I'd been standing on collapsed. Dad broke three ribs when he grabbed me. . . I blew out my knee and got a grade two concussion. *(pause)* [But] out there on the edge, the spinning of the Earth had slowed to give us the time we needed to start finding each other again.

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(Pg 387) Dad called his version of Happily Ever After "Good Enough for Today." *(pause)* Some days were better than others. **(Pg 386-387)** Dad was transferred to a VA rehab place after the hospital. By the time he came home, he'd lost twenty pounds, and looked ten years older, but the shadows had left his face. And he, [finally], remembered how to smile.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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**Cutting compliments of Coach Heather Whitney of Norfolk Public Schools, NE*

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****Introduction statistics source***
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